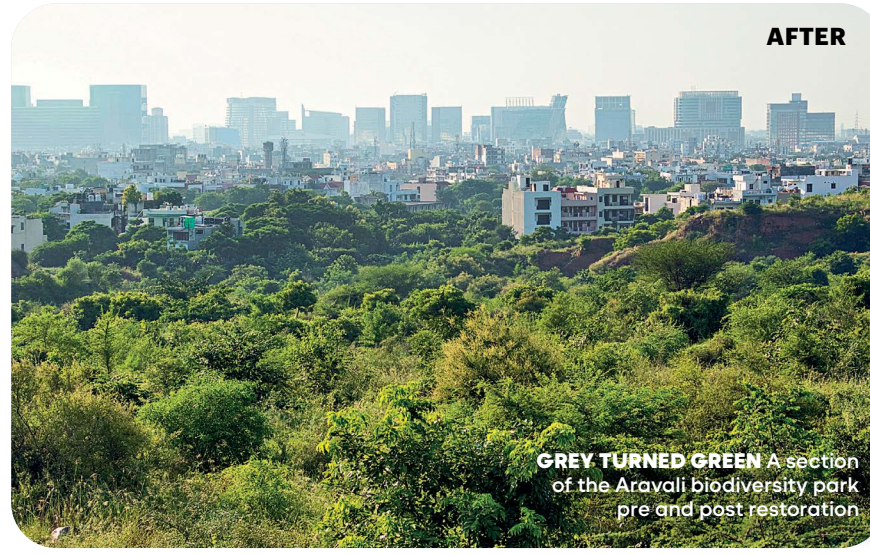
GEMS OF INDIA



ABHIJIT SINGH



GREY TURNED GREEN A section of the Aravali biodiversity park pre and post restoration

VIJAY DHASMANA

When the NGO iamgurgaon first invited Vijay Dhasmana, a pioneering restoration ecologist, to build the Aravali Biodiversity Park in 2011, he encountered a severely degraded site, ravaged by decades of mining, quarrying, cattle grazing and waste dumping. "The extent of the degradation was striking," he recalls. "It was immediately clear that simple plantation or cosmetic greening would not be enough. We needed a larger vision, one that reflected what Gurugram represents: aspiration."

Today, the 392-odd acres of reclaimed wilderness, carved out of an abandoned mining site at the Delhi-Gurugram border, is one of the largest urban ecological restoration efforts in the region.

Instead of conventional landscaping, Dhasmana and his team concentrated on restoring native plant communities and ecological function—"systems that could support life and offer refuge to wildlife," as he puts it. Any scepticism over this approach vanished as the wasteland took shape as a living ecosystem, with over 300 native plant species, a thriving wildlife, including jackals, nilgai, mongoose, and more than 180 bird species.

Validation came in 2016 when the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature), in an independent assessment of the project, recognised it as one of India's most exemplary restoration landscapes.

With that seal of approval for his ecological methodology, the park became a living classroom and research hub as university students, PhD scholars, policymakers and forest department trainees lined up to study its flora, fauna and ecological processes.

Today, the park's influence goes far beyond its acreage—as a case study for Haryana's Aravalli Land Restoration Programme and as inspiration for urban ecological consciousness. Underlining Dhasmana's work is the fundamental belief that protection comes first. "We must save what still remains," he says. "Only after safeguarding our landscapes can rewilding truly begin." And, with it, how cities conceive of nature, resilience and sustainable futures. ■

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Spread over 392 acres, the Aravali Biodiversity Park serves as a carbon sink for millennium city Gurugram**
- **The park now has over 300 species of native plants, including babool, ronjh and hingot, and 185 bird species using the park, besides animals like jungle cat, common palm civet, jackal, porcupine, nilgai**